

Micromouse Documentation

McMaster Micromouse

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Chapter 1

Introduction

1.1 What is Micromouse?

A Micromouse is a small autonomous robot that navigates and solves a maze as quickly as possible. The robot begins with no knowledge of the maze layout and must explore it using external sensors. As it explores, it constructs an internal map of the maze, determines the most efficient route, and then completes subsequent runs at increasingly high speeds.

Micromouse has existed as an international engineering competition hosted by IEEE for decades, and remains a great project for learning embedded systems. A successful Micromouse requires the integration of mechanical design, electronics, and software development.

1.2 Club Objectives

The goal of our club is to make the process of designing, building, and programming a Micromouse accessible to students of all experience levels. Robotics projects often require knowledge from multiple disciplines, which can make them difficult to approach independently. Through structured workshops, hands-on resources, and comprehensive documentation, the club aims to lower this barrier and provide a clear path from beginner to autonomous robot.

Participants will be guided through the complete development process, from assembling hardware and programming embedded systems to implementing sensing, localization, and path-planning algorithms. Rather than simply providing a finished design, the club emphasizes understanding the engineering principles behind each subsystem so members can modify, improve, and extend their own robots.

While the club provides a complete reference robot, members are encouraged to explore their own ideas and improvements. Topics such as custom PCB design, alternative hardware, and advanced control strategies are beyond the scope of the workshops but are left open for exploration. The provided platform should be viewed as a foundation upon which participants can experiment, iterate, and develop their own designs.

1.3 How to Use This Guide

This document serves as both a workshop and technical reference for the Micromouse Club. It is intended to complement our workshops by providing detailed explanation of concepts, design decisions, and implementation details that we may not have time to cover during workshops. It also allows members to revisit or look ahead.

The guide is organized into four main sections:

1. **Hardware:** Introduces the electrical components used in the robot. Explains how they operate and covers wiring.
2. **Software:** Describes sensor integration, motion control, localization, and path- finding algorithms.
3. **Reference Implementation:** Documents the club's reference Micromouse design. This section serves as a starting point for members building their own robots.

Chapter 2

System Overview

2.1 Robot Architecture

2.2 Hardware Overview

2.3 Software Overview

Part I

Hardware

Chapter 3

Materials

3.1 Components

There are a variety of components that can be used for a Micromouse. The main categories are summarized in System Overview. Table 3.1 lists all the components provided in our kits.

Components	Quantity	Purpose
ESP32-DEVKIT	1	Selected microcontroller. Main "brain" of the bot.
VL53L1X	3	Time of Flight sensor. Used to align the bot.
TB6612FNG	1	Motor driver; to control the motors.
G12-N20 Motors	2	Motors for the wheels.
N20 Motor Encoders	2	Attached to motors to track of motor position.
N20 Gear Wheels	2	Wheels for the bot to move.

Table 3.1: Component List

These provide a good starting point for a basic Micromouse bot, and will be the parts we focus on throughout our workshops. The Hardware Theory section will also go in-depth on how each component works. However, you are free to choose your own parts. Some alternative options are described in the next section.

3.2 Alternatives

This section briefly introduces several alternative components that can be used for your own Micromouse, along with the rationale behind our selected components. Keep in mind that the options presented are not exhaustive; you are encouraged to research additional alternatives. A summary list (Table 3.2) is included at the end of this section.

Microcontroller

Micromouse robots require enough of computing power, memory, and peripheral support to handle sensor readings, motor control, and path-finding algorithms. While basic Arduino boards such as the Arduino Uno or Nano(ATmega328P) can be used for simple robots, they become restrictive for

more advanced algorithms.

The STM32 family (e.g. the STM32F103, 'blue pill', 'black pill', and STM32F4 Series) is a popular choice for more advanced Micromouse bots due to its performance, low-level hardware control, and extensive timer and interrupt capabilities. However, due to the learning curve of using the STM32CubeIDE, can be more challenging for beginners. For this reason, an ESP32 board was chosen to provide a more accessible development while still providing sufficient performance for a Micromouse.

Alternative ESP32 boards, such as the ESP32-C3 and ESP32-S3, can also be considered. These boards are smaller and have different peripheral options, but have fewer available GPIO pins compared to some ESP32 development boards. With careful planning, they can still support the required sensors, motor drivers, and encoders.

Distance Sensors

Distance sensors are one of the most important parts of a Micromouse bot. When selecting a sensor, it is important to consider range, update rate, field of view, and physical size.

We will be using the VL53L1X time-of-flight (ToF) sensor due to its relatively long sensing range, accuracy, and size. Alternatives of the ToF sensor include the VL53L0X (shorter range) or VL53L4CX (longer range).

Infrared (IR) distance sensors are another common choice, especially in advanced Micromouses. Compared to ToF sensors, IR sensors have faster update rates and lower latency. However, they require analog signal processing and require more calibration.

Ultrasonic sensors may also be used for slower bots, but are not recommended in general. They are physically larger and are slower since they use a sound waves rather than light.

IMU Sensors

For advanced and faster Micromouses, it is worth considering adding an IMU (inertial measuring unit). Common choices include the MPU6050 and MPU6500. These provide more accurate turns and smoother motion control, but are not strictly necessary for beginner robots. As a result, we have not provided any in the kits as beginner robots work with just wheel encoders.

Motors

Micromouse motors do not need huge amounts of power. The focus is on speed, control, smoothness, size, and accurate encoder readings. Encoders often come together with the motor.

N20 DC Gear Motor would work are common choices for beginner Micromous bots. They come in various gear ratios, are compact, cheap and widely available. The ones we provide have a gear ratio of 30:1, however other ratios can also be used. Coreless DC gear motors are also worth looking into for advanced Micromouses.

Stepper motors are not recommended for Micromouse bots. Although they provide precise position control, they are larger, heavier, consume more power, and have lower speeds and acceleration compared to DC motors.

Motor Driver

The motor driver acts as the bridge between the microcontroller and the motors. Since we are just using N20 gear motors, the chosen motor driver was the TB6612FNG. It is a popular choice for small bots as it is small, cheap and can control two separate motors.

Alternatives include the DRV8833 (similar to TB6612FNG) or the DRV8871 (for larger motors). The L298N is not really recommended due to its bulky size and large voltage drops.

Summary

Components	Selected	Alternative
Microcontroller	ESP32-WROOM	ESP32-C3, ESP32-S3, STM32F103/F4
Distance Sensor	VL53L1X	VL53L0X, VL53L4CX, IR sensors
IMU	None	MPU6050, MPU6500
Motors	N20 DC Gear Motor(30:1)	Other N20 gear ratios, Coreless DC motors
Motor Driver	TB6612FNG	DRV8833, DRV8871

Table 3.2: Summary of Component Alternatives

Chapter 4

Hardware Theory

4.1 ESP32

4.2 Motors

4.3 Motor Driver

4.4 Encoders

4.5 Time-of-Flight Sensors

4.6 Power System

Chapter 5

Electrical Design

5.1 Wiring Schematic

5.2 Pin Assignments

Part II

Software

Chapter 6

Software Architecture

6.1 Project Structure

6.2 Control Loop

Chapter 7

Firmware Setup

7.1 Development Environment

7.2 Libraries

7.3 Uploading Code

Chapter 8

Sensors

8.1 Reading ToF Sensors

8.2 Reading Encoders

8.3 Sensor Calibration

Chapter 9

Motion Control

9.1 Differential Drive

9.2 PID Control

Chapter 10

Mapping and Localization

10.1 Maze Representation

10.2 Localization

10.3 Wall Detection

Chapter 11

Path Planning

11.1 Flood Fill

11.2 Shortest Path Optimization

11.3 Alternative Algorithms

Part III

Reference Implementation

Chapter 12

Mechanical Assembly

Chapter 13

Electronics Assembly

Chapter 14

Firmware Configuration

Chapter 15

Testing

Appendix A

Pinout Tables

Appendix B

Datasheets

Appendix C

Equations

Appendix D

Troubleshooting

Appendix E

Glossary